began to build for the general elections from January 2013 itself. We used the data collected to help shape the Modi campaign,' says Kishore.

The database built by the Modi team was truly formidable. On television, during our election programming, we would do national poll surveys with sample sizes in the range of around 15,000 to 20,000 respondents and feel satisfied. The Modi team had gone many steps beyond us. Its survey in January 2013, for example, had a sample size running into several lakhs and a detailed break-up of voting preferences, according to caste, community, age group. 'I won't reveal any secrets, but I promise you that our surveys would make your analysis look very limited,' claimed Kishore (of course, what he wouldn't say was just how expensive such exercises can be!).

I later found out that the BJP election surveys were supervised by a US-based agency, Penn Schoen Berland, one of the world's leading political campaign and market research groups that had also been involved in the Obama presidential election. This was perhaps the first time in the history of an Indian election that an American company was so deeply involved in poll surveys. 'It only proves the scale of our ambition. We wanted to get the best that money could buy,' is how a BJP leader described their choice of pollsters.

In June 2013, Kishore set up a formal group called Citizens for Accountable Governance (CAG) with an office in Gandhinagar. The group claimed to be non-partisan, but its objective was clear—widen Modi's appeal by showcasing him as a governance icon. Initially, it had just eight to ten full-time employees, but by the time the general elections campaign really kicked off in February 2014, the numbers had swollen to over 200 recruits, some of them working on short-term assignments. Many of the full-time employees at CAG were young, urban professionals who had given up secure jobs to work on the Modi campaign. Akhil Handa, a twenty-nine-year-old IIT Delhi alumnus, was typical. Bright and eager, Akhil had worked with JP Morgan as an investment banker in Hong Kong and was earning a salary running into a few crores, before chucking it all up in mid-2013 to join the Modi campaign. 'I was just tired of seeing my